

SOP Development Guide

Step-by-step guidance to document the processes your business runs on — so quality and speed don't depend on any one person being in the room.

Why SOPs Matter

A Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) turns a process that lives in someone's head into something the business owns. Without SOPs, quality varies by who's doing the work, training new hires takes far longer than it should, and the business can't operate — or be handed off, delegated, or sold — without key individuals.

Step 1 — Choose What to Document First

Don't try to document everything at once. Start with processes that are: repeated often, high-risk if done wrong, and currently known by only one person. Rank your top 10 processes against these three criteria and document the top 3 first.

Step 2 — Use a Consistent SOP Structure

Every SOP should follow the same template so it's easy to read and use under pressure:

Purpose	One sentence: why this process exists.
Scope	What this SOP covers, and what it doesn't.
Owner	Who is accountable for this process staying current.
Steps	Numbered, specific actions in the exact order they happen.
Exceptions	What to do when the standard path doesn't apply.
Review Date	When this SOP is next due for review — not “until someone notices it's wrong.”

Step 3 — Write It With the Person Who Does the Work

SOPs written by management from memory are usually wrong in small but important ways. Shadow the person actually doing the task, write the draft, then have them correct it. This also surfaces informal workarounds worth formalizing — or eliminating.

Step 4 — Review, Version, and Retire

Set a review cadence per SOP (quarterly for fast-changing processes, annually for stable ones). Version every change with a date, and retire SOPs that no longer reflect how the business actually works — an outdated SOP is more dangerous than no SOP at all.

Step 5 — Roll Out and Train

An SOP that lives in a folder no one opens isn't a process improvement — it's documentation theater. Introduce new SOPs in team training, not just email, and check adherence in the first few weeks rather than assuming it happened.